

Playing Futures 2026
Interactive Work Submission

Grow Still: A game-poem

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The realization of an ecologically just world requires more from humanity than simple solutionism. Enacting the values of sustainable flourishing on planet earth will require us to recognize and respect connections between all living things, even those connections which do not appear easily on the surface. What's more, the human organism, both individually and collectively, is vulnerable to the predations of capital, as entities and people with excessive power use what they already have to expand and maintain their control over the rest - "rest" here both in the sense of the "remainder" and the "recuperation." It is within this context of capitalism's cruel fracturing and the planet's need for our collective support and restorative healing that our immersive game-poem *Grow Still* quietly sits, and invites us to slow down along with it.

Many video games and interactive physical installations ask players to collaborate with one another, accomplishing shared goals through cooperative action. Rarely does an interactive game or media work ask us to engage in collective presence, stasis, or imperceptible action. Yet precisely this is what the "game-poem" *Grow Still* requests of participants.

The experience begins on arriving at an exhibition space, where visitors are greeted by robed, masked hosts, standing near a table that displays a collection of unique masks, each composed of bark, flowers, and branches. The hosts invite the participants to don one of the available masks if they are able, and enter the grove (the gallery itself) to commune with the trees.

Moving into the gallery space, the participants will see one wall lit by projection and hear a low eerie (though not unwelcoming) multi-tonal chord playing. Their movement into the room will trigger an ephemeral sparkle in the projection image, which follows their lateral position. On realizing that their motions in the space are watched, some players will attempt to move more

intentionally and look for further response in the projection, but they receive only the same minimal reaction from the space as it notices them.

If another participant is already in the space, or has recently visited, the new arrivals may also see a spectral blossoming tree in the projection, something like a curve-branched cherry tree in bloom. The twisting trunk of the tree and the cold greenish-blue tint of the bark clearly indicates that this is not a specific or realistic plant. Something else is going on here.

After entering the room and spending some time motionlessly looking at the projection, the player may notice that something new is happening. In the area directly in front of them, a new tree is starting to grow. If the visitor stays still in the space, this tree will grow to its full size, and sprout blossoms and leaves. If the visitor moves locations (intentionally or accidentally) before the tree has finished growing, it will retreat and disappear. Eventually through trial and error, or watching other visitors, a visitor will learn that stillness of their trunk is desired, and they will simply stand, or possibly sit down in the space. Some players spontaneously take other collective actions; they hold hands, or face one another and look each other in the eyes.

When at least two people have rooted their trees in the magical grove, something additional will happen. Each tree will begin sending energy out to and receiving energy from the other trees, in a magical connection that appears as swirling energy lines passing from root to root. This mycelial link will remain as long as these individual trees remain in the grove, accompanied by a tinkling sound.

Eventually each visitor decides to leave the grove and return to the mundane world. Providing that they have spent enough time with their own tree, it will have rooted solidly and will continue to bloom for a while longer, connecting with the other trees in the space, both new and old. By this means, the wisdom of community is gathered and passed on to future generations.

Upon departure, visitors return their masks to the grove's protectors, and may take with them a small token of their visit such as a sticker or mini-zine that poetically references the feelings and themes of the experience.

Though trees in a magical grove are its metaphorical roots, *Grow Still* is as much about human nature as it is about a forest. Its interaction offers the somatic experience of being in community while slowing down one's heart rate, allowing the body and mind to rest in a shared low-pressure experience of calm discovery. Our need for both rest and physical companionship was especially acute when this piece was created in early 2023, but it is no less necessary now, as we face climate crisis, and the intentional breaking of collective social bonds by forces that seek to benefit from our isolation. *Grow Still* hopes not to talk *about* these issues, but to directly address the need for communal and ritual experience by offering a space that notices and rewards our restfulness, together.